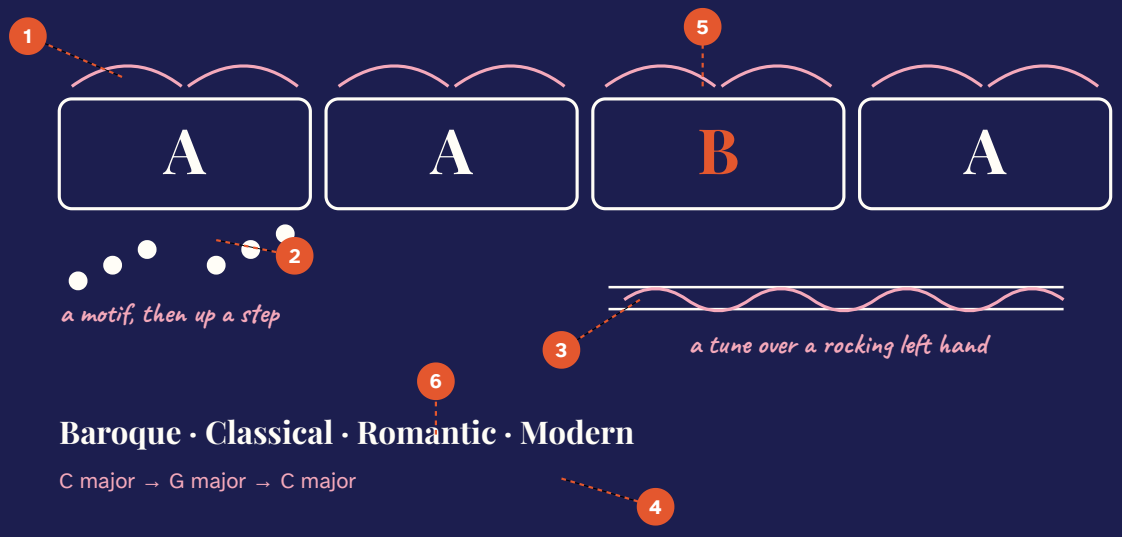
PART VII · HOW MUSIC IS BUILT

Shape and style

Step back from the notes and see the building: small ideas, repeated and moved, in sections that come and go, in the style of their time. Everything in this part is on this map.



1 **Motifs and phrases** p. 145
small ideas build sentences: question and answer

2 **Repetition and sequence** p. 147
say it again, higher, in another voice, or something new

3 **Texture** p. 149
one line, a tune with chords, or tunes woven together

4 **Changing key** p. 151
a new sharp that keeps coming back: a new key

5 **Form** p. 153
the map of a piece: AB, ABA, ABACA, variations

6 **Styles through time** p. 156
Baroque, Classical, Romantic and Modern

★ **Tips: when a piece goes nowhere** p. 158

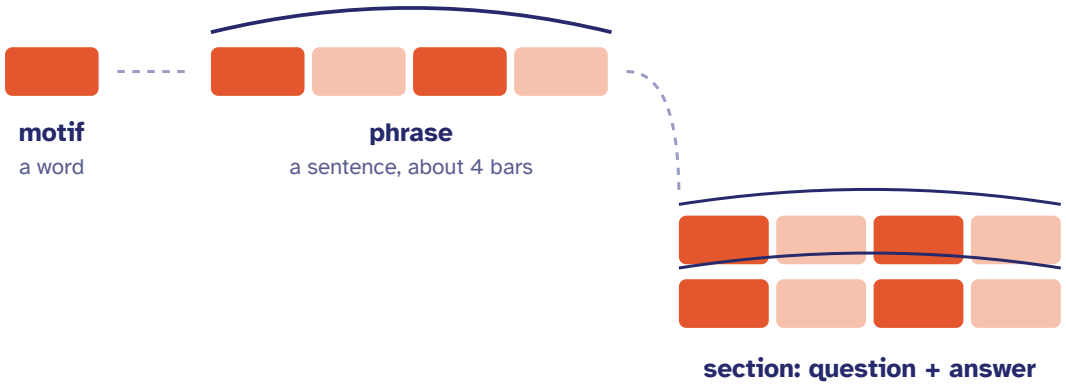
PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 1

Motifs and phrases

A tune is built like a story. A tiny idea, the **motif**, grows into a **phrase**, a musical sentence; two phrases make a question and its answer. Spot the building blocks and a page of notes turns into a few ideas.
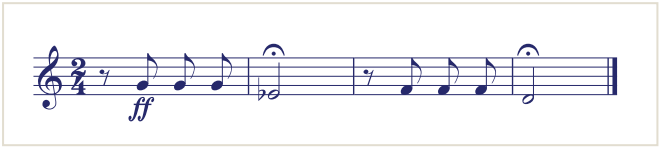
THE SECRET

A motif is a word, a phrase a sentence: a question ends away from home, an answer comes home.
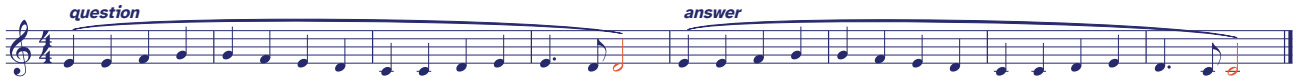


Words, sentences, paragraphs

A motif



Four notes, short-short-short-long: Beethoven builds the whole first movement of his Fifth Symphony from them. A motif is short (2 to 6 notes) and easy to recognise: its **rhythm** and its **shape** come back again and again.

Phrases: question and answer



Ode to Joy: two 4-bar phrases. The first ends on D, away from home (a question); the second comes home to C (an answer).
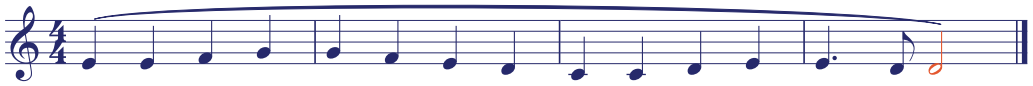
THE RULE

Most phrases are 4 bars long. A question phrase ends away from the key note; the answer comes home to it.

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 1 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Question or answer?
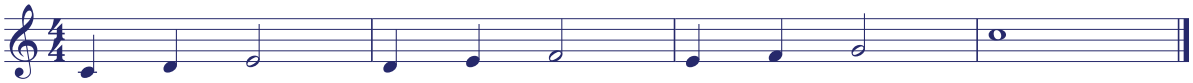


1. **The key is C major.** What is the home note?
2. **The last note** of this phrase is…?
3. **Is it home?**

It ends on D, not C: a **question**. The answer phrase that follows ends on C.

EXAMPLE 2

Find the motif



1. **Look at bar 1:** what shape and rhythm?
2. **Bars 2 and 3:** the same shape?
3. **Where** does each start?

Step, step, long: three notes. It comes **three times**, each a step higher.

GAME
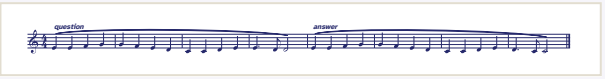
How many phrases?

1	2	3
8 bars	12 bars	16 bars

Each phrase is 4 bars long. How many phrases in a tune of…

Answer: 1 two · 2 three · 3 four.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS
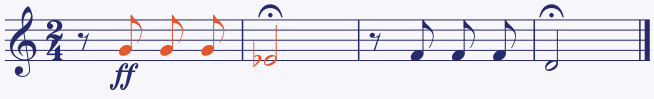


Sing a question, then an answer.

Sing the question and stop on the D: it hangs in the air. Now sing the answer and land on C.

YOU KNOW THIS

Beethoven, Symphony No. 5



"Da-da-da-**DUM**": the most famous motif ever written. Listen to the first minute and count how many times it comes back.

Try it. Tap the rhythm on the lid, then sing it a step lower.

TRAP

× Playing every note the same: each phrase has one high point to grow towards.

SEE ALSO

Slurs and phrases p. 77 · Cadences p. 136

PRACTISE IT

Online: Library › Phrases

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 2

Repetition and sequence

Composers make one idea go a long way. They say it again, say it again higher or lower, let another hand copy it, or say something completely new.
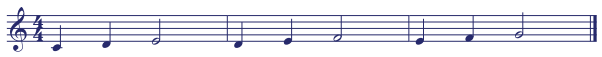
THE SECRET

Again, again higher, again in the other hand, or something new.
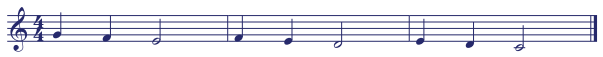


Four ways to use one idea

NAME	WHAT HAPPENS
repetition	the same notes again
sequence	the same shape, starting higher or lower
imitation	another hand or voice copies the idea
contrast	something new: a different shape or rhythm



A rising sequence: C D E, D E F, E F G.

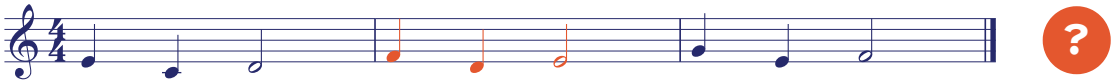


A falling sequence: each step one note lower.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Take any three-note motif and play it as a sequence, starting on every white key from C up to the next C, then back down.

EXAMPLE 1

Repetition or sequence?
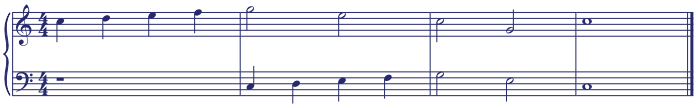


1. **Bar 1:** which notes?
2. **Bar 2:** the same notes, or the same shape on new notes?
3. **Bar 3?**

Same shape, a step higher each bar: a **sequence**.

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 2 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Which hand copies?
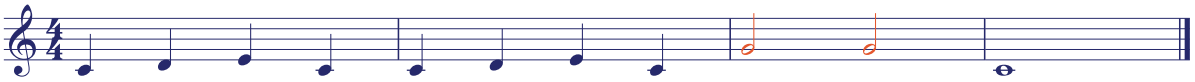


1. **The right hand** starts with C D E F G E C.
2. **The left hand** waits a bar. Then?
3. **Same notes**, how many octaves lower?

The left hand **imitates** the right one bar later, two octaves down.

EXAMPLE 3

Where is the contrast?



1. **Bars 1 and 2:** same or different?
2. **Bar 3:** what changes, the notes or the rhythm?
3. **Bar 4?**

Bars 1–2 repeat; **bar 3** brings something new: long notes on G.

GAME

Which way?

1 same notes

2 one step up

3 left hand copies

4 new rhythm

Name each one.

Answer: 1 repetition · 2 sequence · 3 imitation · 4 contrast.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS
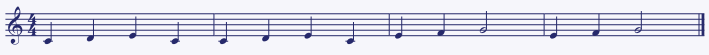


Make a sequence.

Play C D E, then D E F, then E F G with fingers 1 2 3. Now go down: G F E, F E D, E D C.

YOU KNOW THIS

Frère Jacques



Every bar is said **twice**: repetition. Sung as a round, each voice enters two bars after the last: imitation.

Try it. Sing it as a round with a friend.

TRAP

× Calling any repeat a sequence: a sequence moves to new notes.

SEE ALSO

Motifs and phrases p. 145 · Texture p. 149

PRACTISE IT

Online: Library › Patterns

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 3

Texture

Texture is how many lines sound at once, and how they fit together: one line alone, a tune with chords, or several tunes woven together like threads in cloth.

THE SECRET

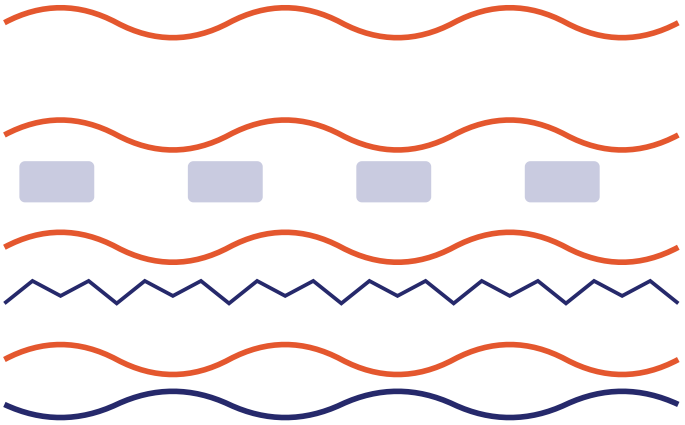
Count the lines: one alone, a tune with chords, or tunes woven together.

one line
monophony

a tune with chords
melody and accompaniment
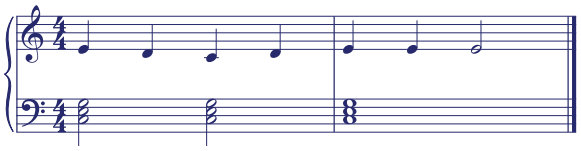
a tune over broken chords
Alberti bass, arpeggios

two tunes at once
polyphony
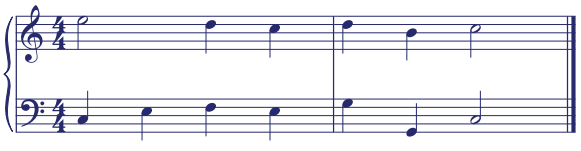


Thin or thick: count the threads

WORD	WHAT YOU HEAR
monophonic	one line alone, or in octaves (unison)
homophonic	a tune with chords underneath: melody and accompaniment
polyphonic (contrapuntal)	two or more tunes at once, each its own
Alberti bass	a broken chord rocking low–high–middle–high
block chords	all the chord notes struck together



Melody and block chords.



Polyphony: two tunes, each with its own rhythm.

GAME

One line or more?

1 **a tune alone**

2 **a tune and chords**

3 **two tunes at once**

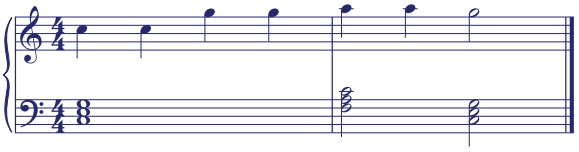
Name the texture.

Answer: 1 monophonic · 2 homophonic · 3 polyphonic.

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Name the texture
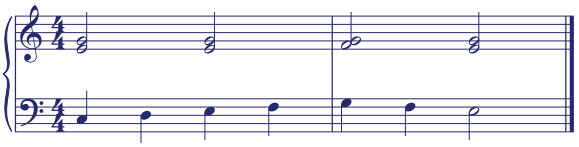


1. **The right hand:** a tune or chords?
2. **The left hand:** a tune or chords?
3. **So** which word?

A tune over chords: **homophonic**, melody and accompaniment.

EXAMPLE 2

Which hand has the tune?
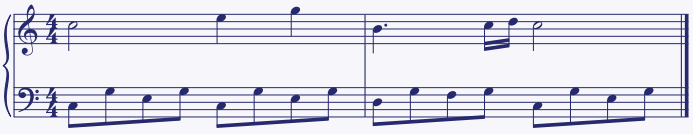


1. **The right hand** repeats two-note chords.
2. **The left hand** moves step by step.
3. **Which one** should sing out?

The **left hand** has the tune: play it louder, keep the right-hand chords soft.

YOU KNOW THIS

Mozart, Sonata in C, K. 545



The right hand sings; the left hand rocks **C G E G**: an Alberti bass, the sound of the Classical style.

Try it. Play only the left hand, softly and evenly.

TRAP

- × Letting the accompaniment cover the tune: tune louder, chords softer.
- × Losing one of two tunes: practise each hand alone and sing it.

SEE ALSO

Chords under a melody p. 139 · Styles p. 156

PRACTISE IT

Online: Library › Texture

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 4

Changing key

Music can travel to a new key and come home again: a **modulation**. The signpost is a new sharp, flat or natural that keeps coming back, and a cadence that lands in the new key.

THE SECRET

A new sharp or flat that keeps coming back, then a cadence: you are in a new key.

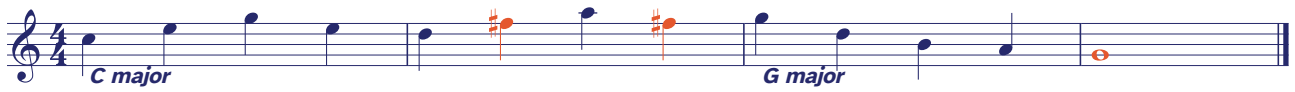


A trip away, and home again

The nearest keys

A piece in C major usually visits the keys next door on the circle of fifths (p. 102): only one note changes.
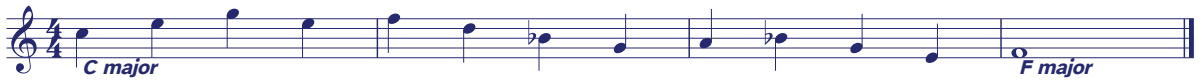
FROM C MAJOR TO	THE SIGNPOST	WHY IT IS CLOSE
G major	F♯ appears	the key a 5th up (one more sharp)
F major	B♭ appears	the key a 4th up (one more flat)
A minor	G♯ appears	the relative minor (same key signature)



Bar 1 in C major; F♯ twice in bar 2, then the phrase lands on G: now G major.

EXAMPLE 1

Where does the key change?



?

1. **Find the accidental.**
2. **Which major key** has one flat, B♭?
3. **Where** does the phrase land?

B♭ in bar 2 and again in bar 3, landing on F: **F major**.

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Which nearby key?

In G major, a C♯ keeps appearing ?

1. **G major** has one sharp, F♯.
2. **C♯ is one more sharp.**
3. **Which key** has F♯ and C♯?

D major, the key a 5th up: one more sharp.

EXAMPLE 3

A new key, or just passing?

One F♯ in a bar of C major, then F♮ everywhere after ?

1. **Does the F♯ come back?**
2. **Is there a cadence** in G?
3. **So**, a new key?

No: one passing F♯ is a decoration. A modulation **keeps** its new note and lands with a cadence.

GAME
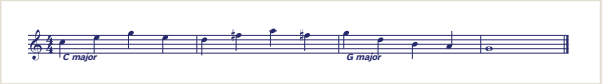
Where to next?

1. C major + F♯
2. C major + B♭
3. G major + C♯
4. F major + E♭

Which nearby key has the music moved to?

Answer: 1 G major · 2 F major · 3 D major · 4 B♭ major.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Hear the pull.

Play the four bars twice: once with F♮ in bar 2, once with F♯. With the F♯, the G at the end sounds like a new home.

THINK OF IT A modulation is a holiday: new scenery for a while, but the piece usually comes home at the end.

TRAP

- × Taking one passing accidental as a new key: it must keep coming back.
- × Missing the way home: most pieces end in the key they began in, so watch for the old note returning.

SEE ALSO

The circle of fifths p. 102 · Cadences p. 136

PRACTISE IT

Online: Library › Keys

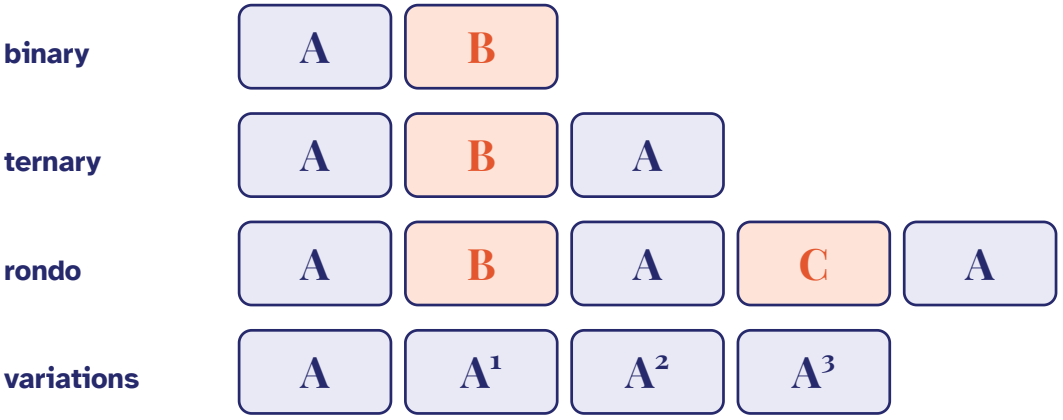
PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 5

Form

Form is the map of a whole piece: which sections come, in what order, and which come back. Letters name them: **A** for the first idea, **B** for the next new one, and so on.

THE SECRET

Same music, same letter. New music, next letter.



The map of a piece, in letters

FORM	LETTERS	SHAPE	YOU KNOW IT FROM
binary	A B	two halves, each often repeated	Baroque dances: minuets, gigues
ternary	A B A	out, away, and back	many short Romantic pieces
rondo	A B A C A	A keeps coming back between new ideas	Beethoven, Für Elise
theme and variations	A A^1 A^2 A^3	one tune, dressed differently each time	Mozart's variations on "Twinkle"
strophic	A A A	the same music for every verse	hymns, folk songs
verse and chorus	V C V C	the chorus words stay the same	pop songs

THE RULE

Same music, same letter. New music, the next letter. A little changed: add a small number (A^1).

LISTEN FOR IT

Petzold
Minuet in G (Notebook for Anna Magdalena Bach; once thought to be Bach's)
binary: two halves, each repeated

Beethoven
Für Elise
rondo: A B A C A

Mozart
Twelve Variations on "Ah vous dirai-je, Maman"
theme and variations, on the tune of Twinkle

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 5 · CONTINUED

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

Sonata form

The big first movements of sonatas and symphonies: an **exposition** (two themes, the second in a new key), a **development** (the themes taken apart and moved through keys), and a **recapitulation** (both themes again, now at home).

EXAMPLE 1

Which letter makes it ternary?



1. **A B** alone: two sections.
2. **Ternary** goes out, away and...?
3. **Which letter** fills the box?

A. A B is binary; A B **A** is ternary.

EXAMPLE 2

Which form?
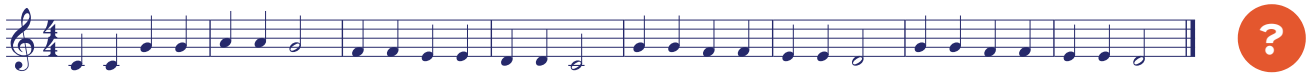


1. **Count the sections.**
2. **Which one keeps coming back?**
3. **What comes between?**

A returns between two new ideas: a **rondo**.

EXAMPLE 3

Map Twinkle



1. **Bars 1–4:** call them A.
2. **Bars 5–8:** new or the same?
3. **The last four bars** (not shown) repeat bars 1–4.

Bars 5–8 are new: B. Then A again: **A B A**, ternary.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



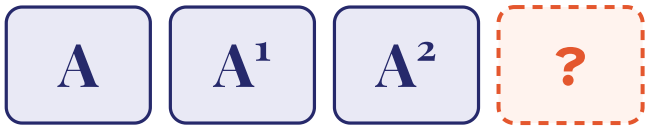
Map a piece you play.

Give every 4-bar phrase a letter. Same music, same letter. What form is it?

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 5 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 4

What comes next?



1. **A** is the theme.
2. **A¹ and A²**: the same tune, dressed differently.
3. **The next one** is called...?

A³: a third variation. Theme and variations keep one tune and change its clothes.

GAME

Name the form

1	2	3	4
A B	A B A	A B A C A	A A¹ A² A³

Name each map.

Answer: 1 binary · 2 ternary · 3 rondo · 4 theme and variations.

HOW TO

Learn a piece by its map

1. **Letter the sections** in pencil.
2. **Learn A first**: it comes back, so it pays twice.
3. **Then the new sections**, and practise the joins between them.

YOU KNOW THIS

Beethoven, Für Elise



The famous opening tune is **A**. It is heard three times, with two new sections in between: a rondo.

Try it. Listen and raise your hand every time A returns.

THINK OF IT Form is the floor plan of a house: once you know the rooms, you never get lost in it.

TRAP

- × Giving every phrase a new letter: same music, same letter.
- × Counting a repeat as a new section: A played twice is still A.

SEE ALSO

Repeats and road signs p. 68 · Changing key p. 151

PRACTISE IT

Online: Library › Form

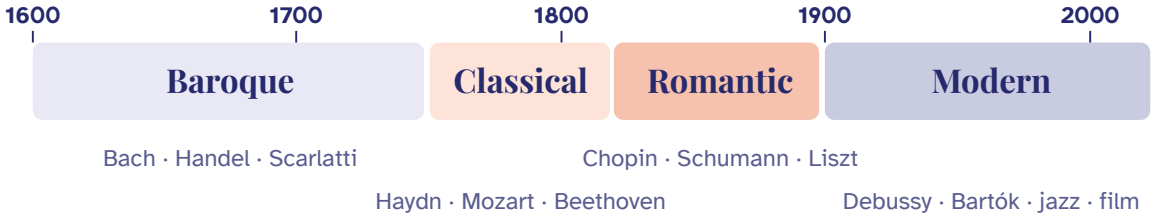
PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 6

Styles through time

Music changes with its time, like clothes and buildings. Four big periods cover most piano music. Each has a sound you can learn to recognise, and a way it likes to be played.

THE SECRET

Listen for the texture, the ornaments and the pedal: they tell you the century.



Four centuries, four sounds

PERIOD	LISTEN FOR
Baroque 1600–1750	harpsichord and organ; two or more tunes woven together; many ornaments; loud or soft in blocks; a steady beat throughout
Classical 1750–1820	the new piano; a clear tune with an Alberti bass; tidy 4-bar phrases; crescendos and contrasts
Romantic 1820–1900	big feelings; rich chords and the pedal; rubato; the whole keyboard, from very soft to very loud
Modern 1900–today	new scales and harmonies, surprising rhythms; impressionism, jazz, minimalism, film music

Playing in style

	PEDAL	TIME	TOUCH
Baroque	little or none	steady	clear, often detached
Classical	light	steady	neat, even, singing tune
Romantic	rich	rubato	deep, legato
Modern	as marked	as marked	whatever the music asks

LISTEN FOR IT

Notebook for Anna Magdalena Bach
Minuet in G (Petzold)
two lines, a steady dance

Mozart
Sonata in C, K. 545
Alberti bass, clear phrases

Chopin
Nocturnes
a singing tune, rubato, pedal

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 6 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Which period?

A tune over an Alberti bass, tidy 4-bar phrases ?

1. **Alberti bass:** which period did it belong to?
2. **Tidy phrases**, question and answer.
3. **So?**

Classical: think Mozart.

EXAMPLE 2

Which period?

Two equal tunes, many trills, written for harpsichord ?

1. **Two tunes woven together**: which texture?
2. **Harpsichord**, before the piano.
3. **So?**

Baroque: think Bach.

EXAMPLE 3

Which period?

Rubato, rich pedalled chords, huge leaps across the keyboard ?

1. **Rubato**: time stretched for feeling.
2. **Rich chords** held in the pedal.
3. **So?**

Romantic: think Chopin.

GAME

Who belongs where?

1	2	3	4
Bach	Mozart	Chopin	Debussy

Match each composer to a period.

Answer: 1 Baroque · 2 Classical · 3 Romantic · 4 Modern.

TRAP

- × Pedalling Bach like Chopin: Baroque music needs little or no pedal.
- × Romantic rubato in Mozart: keep Classical time steady.

SEE ALSO
Ornaments p. 85 · The pedals p. 82

PRACTISE IT
Online: Library › Styles

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · TIPS

When a piece goes nowhere

Every note can be right and the piece still wander. The fix is to see the shape: where the phrases go, what comes back, and where the high point is.

TIP

What you notice, what to check

WHAT YOU NOTICE	CHECK	TURN TO
Every bar sounds the same	**the phrases:** where does each one grow?	p. 145
It feels like a list of notes	**the motif** and its sequences	p. 147
The tune is lost	**the texture:** which line sings?	p. 149
A passage suddenly feels strange	**a new key:** look for the new accidental	p. 151
You lose your place	**the form:** letter the sections	p. 153
It sounds out of style	**the period:** pedal, time and touch	p. 156

Four ways to find the shape

1. **Pencil the phrases**
   Draw a curve over each phrase and mark its high point.
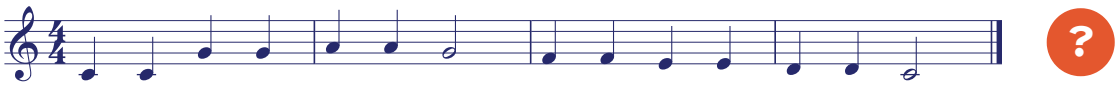
2. **Letter the sections**
   Write A, B, A in the margin. Practise each section on its own.

3. **Sing the tune**
   Sing the top line while you play the rest softly.

4. **Listen to a recording**
   Follow the score and hear the shape before you play it.

EXAMPLE

Where is the high point?



1. **Sing it.**
2. **Which note** is highest?
3. **Grow to it**, then let the phrase fall.

The **As in bar 2**: grow to them, then fall home to C.

THINK OF IT A map does not make the journey, but it stops you getting lost.